



Sucrine (Little Gem Mini Lettuce)

CULTIVARS

- Dragoon
- Bambi
- Winter Density

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 4 rows (8" - 20 cm) per bed spaced every 6" (15 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Sucrine will do great in beds that were previously amended with compost and fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) or sprinkler

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Shallow (6"-24")
- General: Water consistently for succulent growth and to avoid bitter taste.

IMPLANTATION

Sucrine is a good crop to grow for restaurants or other sales outlets where deliveries can be expected weekly over a long period of the year. They are somewhat frost tolerant, chic and generate great yields per square foot. We plant sucrine every 2 weeks to ensure a constant supply throughout our growing season. For every seeding, we plan enough beds for an estimated 2 weeks of harvest.

In our planting program, sucrine is grouped with green onions, chicory, mini-fennel and head lettuce—all crops that stay in the fields +/- 50 days and that have similar crop requirements.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- 30" bed prep rake
- Popping tray and marking roller

ITINERARY

- Remove tarp and clean out large debris. Use the rake if needed. *
- Uniformly apply amendments and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). To make transplanting easier (seeing as the soil is loose after being harrowed), we only prepare the beds when we are about to transplant.
- Pass with the dibbler-roller to mark the planting holes and bring out the well-watered trays.
- Once the beds are ready, 1 person will drop the seedlings while 2 others transplant as fast as possible. Sucrine seedlings are very hardy and don't need special care. 3 people/100' bed is a good ratio for efficient workflow.
- Install irrigation and water the soil until it is deeply moistened.

* If the previous crop is too well established, or if the bed is too messy, mow the crop as low as possible and harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). Add 1" (2.5 cm) of compost evenly spread on the whole width of the bed and transplant into compost following a no-till strategy.

WEEDING

- Sucrines are cultivated using the flex tine weeder 10 to 12 days after implantation when the weeds are at the filament/cotyledon stage. In weedy beds, a second pass should be planned 7 days later.

PLANT PROTECTION

- Slugs and aphids are sometimes present, but rarely enough to justify an intervention.

HARVEST

- Sucrines are harvested in the fields in a kneeling position.
- Harvesting is done using a VERY sharp knife. Sharpen your blades before each harvest; this will help reduce potential oxidation (browning or discolouration) on the cut surface. For the same reason, do not use carbon or rusted blades for that same reason.
- Kneeling in the pathway, 1 person harvests 2 rows at a time, pushing the bin in front of them, then coming back to harvest the other 2 rows.
- Harvest only the lettuces that have dense hearts. Remove slugs and dead or damaged leaves if necessary.
- Do not overfill bins, you must be able to stack them without damaging the lettuces.

CONDITIONING

- The sucrine heads are washed by quickly dunking them in a sink full of cold water.
- Use both hands (one lettuce head in each hand) to shake out any excess and place them on a screen facing down to let them drip-dry for a moment. Make sure the sucrine is in the water for no longer than a minute to avoid getting waterlogged.
- Pack the sucrine tightly in storage totes, stacking them upside down to let the water drain while sitting in the cooler.

STORING

- Sucrines are stored in a cold room at 35 °F (2 °C) and should not be stored for more than 3 days before being sold.